

Tobias Treppmann

Design leader who builds the infrastructure — design systems as APIs, and a build that refuses off-system work

CONTACT

LOCATION

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LINKEDIN

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EDUCATION

M.A. Leadership

Kairos University, South Dakota, USA

2022 – 2026

Theological Studies

Theologisches Seminar Rheinland

2003 – 2007

LANGUAGES

German · native

English · C2, fluent

ONGOING

Independent Consultant

Oratio&Co

2016 – Present · Remote

Collaborative leadership coaching and product-strategy consulting for mission-driven organisations.

PROFILE

I build the machinery that keeps UI quality from depending on whether anyone is watching. At Bibel TV the design system ships as an API rather than a Figma file, and the build refuses off-system work: six checks that fail before drift lands. Run over a library believed clean after two cleanup passes, it found 32 off-system values. I did that without a platform team, in an organisation with no design function at all, at the moment AI assistants started writing the frontend. Before that, fifteen years in B2B and consumer software, including four months at Ninox holding design and product at the same time — nine people across design, UX writing, product management and data science.

EXPERIENCE

Head of Product Design

2025 – Present

Bibel TV (broadcaster in linear-to-streaming transformation — iOS, Android, web, connected TV; no in-house design team, engineering is an external agency) · Hamburg + Berlin, Germany

- A design system the build enforces — Storybook as the source of truth with a prototyping layer on top, and six checks that run identically locally and in CI. Two of them reject exactly the failure modes I watched an AI assistant produce: a reference to a token that does not exist, and a colour, size or duration written straight into a component. Both compile. Both render. I know that system as well as anyone and could not catch either by reading. Run over a library believed clean after two cleanup passes, it surfaced 32 off-system values.
- Design system as an API — DTCG tokens in three tiers from global primitives through semantic to component, built with Style Dictionary, synced live to Figma and Android. One commit propagates to every platform, so the high-quality choice is the fast one. Built without a platform team.
- A colour engine, and the tool that configures it — k-means clustering in OKLCH rather than RGB, so themes carry even perceptual weight across a grid. Text is validated against base with the WCAG algorithm, lightness and chroma adjusted until the pair passes. No theme ships failing contrast. Every threshold is a dial in the config tool rather than a commit.
- AI-enablement in frontend, in production for a year — I prototype against real APIs, web first then Android. Around 70% of the AI-generated code reaches production with minor modification and iteration moved from days to hours. Engineering is an external agency, so that handoff crosses a company boundary and holds anyway.

Head of Product Design · Interim Head of Product

2023 – 2024

Ninox Software GmbH (no-code business platform — DACH / UK / US) · Berlin, Germany

- Two functions at once, nine reports, four disciplines — from July to October 2023 I held Product Design and Product together. Design was five people, split between product design and UX writing, including a design lead. Product was four: three product managers and a data scientist. Senior Leadership Team throughout.
- Design made co-equal, by agreement rather than assertion — a collaborative self-assessment with product and engineering, after which design held parity in planning instead of receiving finished decisions. Shared design-system governance established across four designers and engineering, run as a cross-functional working group with an escalation path.
- Hired 2, promoted 2, and made the other call twice — including hiring the consultant who then took Head of Product permanently.
- Prompt-to-database onboarding, with the CEO and technical co-founder (freelance, summer 2025) — the AI-generated schema renders into the real data-model editor, not a chat preview, so people can inspect and correct what the model produced. It became the basis for the public AI beta.

Head of Platform and Design

2024 – 2025

ChurchDesk (vertical ERP for churches and dioceses — ~50 people, DE / DK / UK / SE / NO / CH) · Copenhagen, Denmark · Remote from Berlin

- Accessibility shipped under regulation, not advocated — AI alt-text generation for EU accessibility compliance, under GDPR plus Protestant and Catholic church data-protection law, across six countries.
- Booking module — the decision I defended through the build — inherited a €20k client-funded project scoped internally as a standalone add-on and reframed it into a platform capability, choosing deep integration over the faster module and holding that line to delivery. 70% coordination-time reduction and 90% acceptance at the launch customer. It then shipped to every customer as general booking.
- Product management and all of product design at once — I wrote the specs, ran the ticket board engineering worked from, and was the launch customer's main contact throughout.

Director of Design

2016 – 2021

Datameer GmbH (collaborative data analytics for top US / CA / UK banks and insurers) · Berlin, Germany · team across Germany and NYC

- Five years of data-dense enterprise interfaces — pivot tables, column charts, aggregated JSON views, result cards and filter logic. The hardest was the query-builder preview, where the result is a sample and the interface has to say so without becoming unreadable.
- Design system, co-built — UX defined component behaviour and specs. UI executed the visual system. I led the design team across Germany and NYC throughout, and pioneered iterative usertesting.com screening to reach analysts working inside regulated banks and insurers.

Product & UX Strategist

2021 – 2022

Hypoport hub SE (shared services arm of listed Hypoport SE) · Berlin / Lübeck, Germany · Remote

- Service-to-product transformation — partnered with the executive team to productise the service organisation. Case-by-case support became a standard catalogue. Ran design-thinking training for that leadership team and for the service teams.

EARLIER CAREER PROGRESSION

UX Strategy Lead · *Spreadshirt (200+ people; outside-in shift across a matrix organisation)* · 2014 – 2016 · Leipzig, Germany

UX Manager · *HairDirect* · 2013 – 2014 · Lancaster, PA, USA

User Experience Designer · *andCulture* · 2012 – 2013 · Harrisburg, PA, USA

Web Designer & Front-End Developer · *HOPE International* · 2009 – 2012 · Lancaster, PA, USA

Web Designer · *Bajaa.com* · 2008 – 2009 · Düsseldorf, Germany

Freelance Web Designer · 2003 – 2008 · Düsseldorf, Germany

Web Designer · *Bajaa.com* · 2000 – 2003 · Düsseldorf, Germany

SKILLS

Design Infrastructure and Frontend Technologies

Design system as an API at Bibel TV: DTCG tokens in three tiers from global primitives through semantic to component, Style Dictionary, live sync to Figma and Android · One commit propagates to every platform · Storybook as the source of truth with a prototyping layer on top · Six checks, identical locally and in CI, that refuse off-system work · 32 off-system values surfaced in a library believed clean · The system reports its own token gaps: eight so far, in the order people hit them

AI-Enablement in Frontend and Design

Agentic engineering in production for a year · Prototypes built in real code against real production APIs, web first then Android · Around 70% of AI-generated code reaches production with minor modification, and iteration moved from days to hours · The handoff crosses a company boundary to an external engineering agency and holds anyway · The token vocabulary handed to the assistant as an enumerated list rather than recalled, so it cannot invent · Claude Code, Claude skills, Cursor and Zed as daily tools

Craft Leadership and Visual Strategy

Built Bibel TV's colour engine and the tool that configures it, both live in production · K-means clustering in OKLCH rather than RGB, so themes carry even perceptual weight across a grid · Text validated against base with the WCAG algorithm and adjusted until the pair passes, so no theme ships failing · Selah — Mindful Transitions: a macOS app designed, built and shipped solo on the Mac App Store

Leading More Than One Team

Product Design and Product held together at Ninox from July to October 2023 · Nine reports across four disciplines — product design, UX writing, product management and data science · Senior Leadership Team · Hired two, promoted two, and made the other call twice · Design team across Germany and NYC for five years at Datameer · Design-system governance run as a cross-functional working group with an escalation path

Accessibility and Regulated Delivery

AI alt-text generation shipped for EU accessibility compliance at ChurchDesk · Under GDPR plus Protestant and Catholic church data-protection law, across six countries · WCAG contrast validated inside the colour engine rather than checked afterwards · Datameer operated under HIPAA compliance among other frameworks

Organisational Change

Design established as co-equal with product and engineering at Ninox through a collaborative self-assessment rather than an imposed model · Outside-in shift across a 200-plus person matrix organisation at Spreadshirt · Service-to-product transformation with the executive team at Hypoport · Collaboration norms redesigned around how people actually work, which outlived the case that prompted them